

MSP | MSP-09

Programme Business Case

Aggregated investment justification for the programme

Meridian Group

Programme Helios — Infrastructure and Platform Stack for AI GPU Compute at Scale

Field	Detail
Document title	Programme Business Case
Document reference	MSP-09-HEL-T2-v1.0
Project / Programme	Programme Helios
Version	1.0
Status	Baselined
Date	18 Sep 2026
Author	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager
Owner	Senior Responsible Owner
Approver	Sponsoring Group
Classification	Internal
Retention	7 years from programme closure

Document control

Version history

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
0.1	04 Jun 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Initial draft
0.2	21 Jul 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Updated following workstream lead review
1.0	18 Sep 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Baselined at the Tranche 2 funding gate

Reviewers

Name	Role	Review scope	Date reviewed
T. Nakamura, Chief Platform Architect	Chief Platform Architect	Technical content and solution alignment	08 Sep 2026
L. Haddad, CISO	CISO	Security, assurance and residency content	10 Sep 2026
C. Whitfield, Finance Business Partner	Finance Business Partner	Cost, funding and benefit figures	11 Sep 2026
M. Verity, Head of P3O	Head of P3O	Governance standards and completeness	15 Sep 2026

Approval

This product is baselined once approval is recorded below. Any subsequent change must go through change control.

Name	Role	Decision	Date
R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO	Senior Responsible Owner / Group CTO	Approved	18 Sep 2026
H. Farrell, Director of Infrastructure	Director of Infrastructure	Approved	18 Sep 2026
L. Haddad, CISO	CISO	Approved subject to closure of ISS-003	18 Sep 2026

Related products

Reference	Product	Relationship
MSP-06	Benefit Profile	Source of benefit values
MSP-08	Programme Plan	Source of cost and timescale
MSP-19	Programme Risk Register	Aggregate exposure

How to use this template

Aspect	Guidance
Purpose	Aggregates the costs, benefits, timescales and risks of the whole programme, including its component projects and business change, to demonstrate that the investment remains justified.
Framework	MSP — Justification theme; created in Define the Programme; reviewed at every tranche boundary
Created when	Define the Programme
Reviewed / updated	At every tranche boundary and on significant change
Owner	Senior Responsible Owner
Approver	Sponsoring Group
Format options	Document, presentation, register entry, or tool record — the content matters, not the medium.
Tailoring	Scale the depth of each section to the scale, risk and complexity of the work. Delete sections that add no value and record the tailoring decision in the governance approach.

This is a worked example. Every field has been completed with illustrative content for Programme Helios, a fictional AI GPU infrastructure and platform programme. All example content is shown in grey italic — the black text is the template itself. Replace the grey italic content with your own.

Quality criteria

Use these to check the product is fit for purpose before submitting it for approval.

- It aggregates rather than duplicates project business cases
- Programme management and business change costs are included, not just project costs
- The value of the programme exceeds the sum of independently delivered projects — and that increment is stated
- Benefit realisation extends beyond programme closure and this is reflected in the appraisal period

Contents

Document control.....	2
Version history.....	2
Reviewers.....	2
Approval.....	2
Related products.....	2
How to use this template.....	3
Quality criteria.....	3
1. Executive summary.....	5
2. Strategic case.....	5
3. The case for a programme.....	5
4. Options appraisal.....	5
5. Costs.....	6
Programme cost summary.....	6
Ongoing operating cost impact.....	6
6. Benefits summary.....	7
7. Dis-benefits summary.....	7
8. Investment appraisal.....	8
9. Sensitivity analysis.....	8
10. Funding and affordability.....	9
11. Risks to the case.....	9
12. Review record.....	10

1. Executive summary

Programme Helios consolidates fragmented AI compute onto a single shared platform in DXB-1, scaling to 2,048 GPUs in Tranche 2 and 4,096 by Tranche 3. The decision requested is release of AED 118m of Tranche 2 capital at the 18 September 2026 gate.

The return is AED 14.3m of annual public cloud rental substituted, utilisation lifted from 31% to 72%, and median training cycle time cut from 11.5 days to 3 days. The principal risk to viability is vendor GPU allocation slipping beyond November 2026 (RSK-001), which would defer the benefit by a quarter.

2. Strategic case

Why this change, why now, and how it serves organisational strategy.

Programme Helios — Tranche 2 scale build, DXB-1 halls A and B. Dependent on the Enterprise Identity Programme (DEP-003). Detail is maintained by the Senior Responsible Owner and reviewed at the monthly Programme Board.

3. The case for a programme

The incremental value delivered by managing this as a programme rather than as independent projects — coordination, shared capability, sequencing, aggregated benefit.

Programme Helios — Tranche 2 scale build, DXB-1 halls A and B. Excluded from Tranche 2 and deferred to the AUH-2 second site. Detail is maintained by the Senior Responsible Owner and reviewed at the monthly Programme Board.

4. Options appraisal

Option	Description	NPV	Risk	Deliverability	Recommendation
Do nothing	Continue with four departmental GPU estates and growing public cloud rental	Escalated to the Portfolio Board where it exceeds programme tolerance	Cost growth is unbounded and four residency exceptions remain open	Verified at hall A acceptance on 26 Feb 2027	Baseline only. Rejected — fails the residency obligation.
Do minimum	Signed container image supply chain with admission enforcement and firmware attestation	Reported through the monthly benefit tracking report	No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance	Constrained by the 6.2 MVA site limit at DXB-1 until 2028	23 Apr 2027
Preferred option	Option A — add a second CDU to hall A	Do nothing	No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance	Option B — accept 48 kW density and cap at 1,536 GPUs	23 Apr 2027

5. Costs

Programme cost summary

Category	Yr 1	Yr 2	Yr 3	Yr 4	Total
Project delivery costs	AED 623,000	AED 1,246,000	AED 1,869,000	AED 2,492,000	AED 91,200,000
Business change costs	AED 2,870,000	AED 5,740,000	AED 8,610,000	AED 11,480,000	AED 17,800,000
Programme management	AED 1,610,000	AED 3,220,000	AED 4,830,000	AED 6,440,000	AED 13,600,000
Assurance and governance	AED 6,020,000	AED 12,040,000	AED 18,060,000	AED 24,080,000	AED 24,300,000
Transition and decommissioning	AED 2,870,000	AED 5,740,000	AED 8,610,000	AED 11,480,000	AED 6,800,000
Contingency	AED 1,610,000	AED 3,220,000	AED 4,830,000	AED 6,440,000	AED 11,200,000
Total investment	AED 1,610,000	AED 3,220,000	AED 4,830,000	AED 6,440,000	AED 8,400,000

Ongoing operating cost impact

Area	Current annual cost	Future annual cost	Net change
<i>Excludes AUH-2, model development and business-unit data engineering</i>	AED 91,200,000	AED 96,000	<i>Defer confidential computing enabler from Tranche 2 to Tranche 3</i>
<i>Platform, MLOps and security workstreams across the Agile Release Train</i>	AED 1,120,000	AED 4,200,000	<i>Integration partner claim for additional structural works</i>
<i>DXB-1 halls A and B, 2,048 accelerators and the supporting fabric and storage</i>	AED 17,800,000	AED 91,200,000	<i>Bridge the hall B row 3 service void rather than relocate racks</i>
<i>DXB-1 halls A and B, 2,048 accelerators and the supporting fabric and storage</i>	AED 240,000	AED 1,120,000	<i>Dual-source 20% of Tranche 2 accelerator volume</i>
<i>Platform, MLOps and security workstreams across the Agile Release Train</i>	AED 11,200,000	AED 17,800,000	<i>Add coolant leak detection integration to the NOC</i>

6. Benefits summary

Benefit ref	Benefit	Category	Value Yr1	Value Yr2	Value Yr3	Total	Owner
BEN-01	Reduced external GPU rental spend	Financial — cashable	AED 0	AED 6,200,000	AED 14,300,000	AED 20,500,000	V. Chandra, Head of AI Enablement
BEN-02	Faster model training cycle time	Non-financial — productivity	AED 0	AED 1,900,000	AED 3,400,000	AED 5,300,000	N. Ozturk, ML Platform Lead
BEN-03	Improved compute utilisation	Financial — cost avoidance	AED 0	AED 4,100,000	AED 8,800,000	AED 12,900,000	P. Raghavan, Platform Engineering Lead
BEN-04	Reduced time to provision AI environments	Non-financial — agility	AED 0	AED 900,000	AED 1,600,000	AED 2,500,000	P. Raghavan, Platform Engineering Lead
BEN-05	Data residency and sovereignty assurance	Non-financial — risk reduction	AED 0	AED 0	AED 0	Non-financial	L. Haddad, CISO
BEN-06	New revenue from AI-enabled products	Financial — revenue	AED 0	AED 0	AED 8,600,000	AED 8,600,000	V. Chandra, Head of AI Enablement
BEN-07	Reduced energy cost per unit of training work	Financial — efficiency	AED 0	AED 1,200,000	AED 2,700,000	AED 3,900,000	A. Kowalski, Data Centre Lead
BEN-08	Retention of scarce AI engineering talent	Non-financial — capability	AED 0	AED 0	AED 0	Non-financial	F. Mansour, Business Change Lead

7. Dis-benefits summary

Ref	Dis-benefit	Affected group	Value	Mitigation
DIS-01	Legacy departmental GPU clusters are decommissioned, removing local control	Fraud Analytics and Research teams	AED 17,800,000	Guaranteed fair-share quota and priority queue for time-critical work, published in the service catalogue
DIS-02	Chargeback introduces a visible cost where compute was previously treated as free	All consuming business units	AED 240,000	Twelve-month transition at subsidised rates; rate card published a full budget cycle in advance
DIS-03	Facilities team must acquire and sustain liquid-cooling competence	Service Operations and FM provider	AED 11,200,000	Vendor training funded for eight staff; 4-hour on-site vendor cover for the first year

8. Investment appraisal

Measure	Value	Basis / assumption
Total investment	AED 91,200,000	Departmental autonomy is removed with no compensating guarantee
Total benefit (appraisal period)	Penetration testing, acceptance benchmarking, independent assurance review — AED 1,900,000	Penetration testing, acceptance benchmarking, independent assurance review — AED 1,900,000
Net present value	AED 96,000	AED 1,120,000
Internal rate of return	AED 240,000	AED 1,120,000
Payback period	AED 96,000	Chargeback introduces cost where compute was previously free
Benefit-cost ratio	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation
Discount rate applied	AED 4,200,000	AED 91,200,000
Appraisal period	Penetration testing, acceptance benchmarking, independent assurance review — AED 1,900,000	Penetration testing, acceptance benchmarking, independent assurance review — AED 1,900,000

9. Sensitivity analysis

How the case changes under adverse assumptions — benefit shortfall, cost overrun, delay.

Scenario	Assumption varied	Effect on NPV	Case still viable?
Benefits -20%	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation
Costs +20%	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation
12-month delay	Reviewed at each PI boundary by the Release Train Engineer	On-call rota cannot be sustained beyond a 5x8 model at handover	Dependent on the Enterprise Identity Programme (DEP-003)
Combined downside	Applies from hall A handover; hall B follows in Tranche 2 closure	Hall A capacity capped at 1,536 GPUs until resolved	Reflected in the solution intent as a fixed constraint

10. Funding and affordability

Funding source	Amount	Type	Approval status	Conditions
Assurance evidence pack, Tranche 2 gate	AED 91,200,000	Organisational	Not started	Agreed with the integration partner at design freeze, 15 Oct 2026
ALM tool — Helios ART board	AED 17,800,000	Commercial	Open	Applies from hall A handover; hall B follows in Tranche 2 closure
Solution intent wiki, DXB-1 platform space	AED 13,600,000	Security	In progress	Funded from the Tranche 2 allocation of AED 118,000,000
Programme SharePoint — Helios / Tranche 2 / Governance	AED 24,300,000	Facilities	Complete	Applies only to workloads classified Restricted or above
Configuration management database	AED 6,800,000	Technical	Not started	Applies across DXB-1 halls A and B for the Tranche 2 scale build

11. Risks to the case

Ref	Risk	Financial exposure	Response
RSK-001	Because GPU allocation is constrained by vendor quota, the Tranche 2 hardware delivery may slip beyond November 2026, causing the platform build to start late and the AI enablement benefit to be deferred by a quarter	Fabric tuning falls short of the 92% all-reduce target (RSK-005)	Allocation confirmed in writing at contract award; 20% of Tranche 2 volume dual-sourced; staged acceptance so hall A can proceed independently of hall B
RSK-002	Because DXB-1 hall B was designed for 8 kW racks, the 60 kW liquid-cooled racks may exceed the available floor loading and chilled water capacity, causing a redesign mid-build	Hall B cooling capacity limits achievable rack density (RSK-002)	Structural survey completed before hall B order; CDU capacity modelled at N+1; contingency for a reduced 1,536-GPU configuration held
RSK-003	Because the platform will host model weights and training data from three business units, weak tenant isolation may allow cross-tenant data access, causing a reportable data incident and loss of regulatory standing	Vendor allocation slippage defers the Tranche 2 benefit by a quarter (RSK-001)	Namespace and network policy isolation validated by penetration test before multi-tenant go-live; per-tenant KMS keys; quarterly control testing
RSK-004	Because the platform engineering skill set is scarce in-market, recruitment of the six planned SRE roles may take longer than three months, causing the MLOps workstream to depend on contractors beyond Tranche 2	Slow workload migration leaves the platform under-used (RSK-015)	Two contractors engaged from October 2026 with knowledge-transfer clauses; internal conversion programme from the infrastructure team
RSK-	Because the 400G RoCEv2 fabric is new to	Fabric tuning falls	NCCL benchmark gate at pilot exit;

Ref	Risk	Financial exposure	Response
005	<i>the organisation, congestion control tuning may not achieve the target 92% collective communication efficiency, causing training job throughput to fall short of the business case</i>	<i>short of the 92% all-reduce target (RSK-005)</i>	<i>vendor performance engineering engaged for two weeks per hall; fallback to reduced job scale documented</i>

12. Review record

Review point	Date	NPV at review	Still justified?	Decision
15 Oct 2026	18 Sep 2026	25 Jun 2027	<i>Excluded from Tranche 2 and deferred to the AUH-2 second site</i>	<i>Rejected</i>
18 Sep 2026	25 Jun 2027	28 May 2027	<i>Delegated to the Programme Manager within the agreed tolerance</i>	<i>Approved</i>
25 Jun 2027	28 May 2027	23 Apr 2027	<i>Applies from hall A handover; hall B follows in Tranche 2 closure</i>	<i>Approved with conditions</i>
28 May 2027	23 Apr 2027	31 Mar 2027	<i>Maintained by the P3O as part of the assurance evidence library</i>	<i>Deferred to the next Board</i>